

Episode 155: Long Ago... 93 1995 Part 13 Learning Macintosh Through Part-Time Work July-August

Setsubun, then Risshun - spring has arrived on the calendar. These past few days in Tokyo, the air feels somewhat spring-like, and the cold has lost its temporary severity. The plum blossoms bloomed too. Ah, winter is ending.

Somehow, I feel lonely about seasons changing. Summer has summer's enjoyments, winter has winter's flavours. Did I properly enjoy winter this winter? I think such things. Every season, nearing its end, I always ask myself this.

I didn't think like this when young, but now that the big 50 is coming into view, I'm gradually becoming concerned about remaining time. Too early? No no, really, how many more years can my body stay healthy and push itself? I think seriously about this. And how many more times can I welcome and enjoy winter? Life is short when you notice.

Our memories are built on the changing seasons that repeat yearly. Did I make good memories this winter? Am I leaving proper work behind? And when spring comes, I'll probably ponder the same way when it ends.

Anyway, spring is really coming soon. Ah, but before that, couldn't it snow and accumulate properly just once? thinks this Tokyo person (laugh).

Anyway.

The PowerMacintosh 8100AV I'd bought anyway. I had to fiddle with it thoroughly to somehow learn to use it. Despite having almost no knowledge about digital or computers, I'd bought it. So I had equipment but only partially knew how to use it.

For example, suppose I scan line art and try to colour it. Scan the image with a scanner, binarize it, then connect broken lines in Photoshop while carefully painting... I vaguely understood the procedure because Toei Animation had workshop-like things for such areas, so I could somehow understand by watching and learning, but I didn't know guidelines for basic image resolution and size for working with imported images. Naturally, required size changes depending on image purpose - what resolution should I work at? I didn't understand even that. Furthermore, what type of image should it be? .pct, .tga, .psd, .jpg... How exactly do these differ? Particularly .pct and .tga look the same, don't they?

I had to start by understanding such basic knowledge experientially or by researching in books. Fortunately, I had very basic video signal and imaging knowledge studied briefly in college, which helped somewhat, but almost everything was new.

Just then, I received a phone call.

"Hey hey Tsujita-kun, you bought a Mac? Immediately, want to do part-time work? (laugh)"

It was a call from Okubo-san, who had been helping me in various ways. He was a senior who had been a producer at Toei Animation, became independent and ran a small production company, and I'd been doing part-time work for him here and there. What kind of part-time work had I done? Still image work like colour direction (色指定) and colouring for game guidebook and magazine cover illustration cel paintings, to animation footage work for TV commercials. I also participated in several NHK *Minna no Uta* videos. All were cel animation.

Incidentally, among *Minna no Uta* pieces I participated in was a masterpiece (←I think (laugh)) called "Jagaimo Jagar," where I handled both cel work colours and art. Direction and animation were also handled by acquaintances who were at Toei Animation then. Like that, daily life was extremely busy, but since it offered different experiences from working at Toei, I did part-time work here and there.

Now, this Okubo-san had already equipped his company with several Macs by then and was increasingly entering digital video work like game software opening footage. Since individuals buying Macs for work were still rare, Okubo-san wouldn't miss such opportunities (laugh).

"First, I'd like to ask you to do the painting for this," he said, offering what I believe was still image material for PlayStation game "Tokyo Dungeon" opening. Immediate meetings with Okubo-san and animator Umetsu Yasuomi-san. And soon afterward, actual work began.

"But you know, Okubo-san, I still don't understand Mac at all."

"Yeah. I'll teach you, so it's fine! (laugh)"

Thus began part-time work with Okubo-san's "Mac Course" included. About twice weekly, Okubo-san would come to my room for exchanges that I found endlessly enjoyable. This was truly grateful. He taught me from the very basics and answered my ridiculous questions carefully. Resolution problems I mentioned earlier, video material points and resolution guidelines for print materials, Photoshop tips, clever scanner usage, etc. Furthermore, everything from ISDN line details to video editing software like Director and Premiere, usage of Mac basic software like Quicktime and Hypercard. Without this part-time work offer, without Okubo-san, would I have come to love computer work and Mac this much? I'm truly grateful to Okubo-san.

So my first digital work was actually this part-time "Tokyo Dungeon" before *Neighbourhood Story* work. And I continued doing part-time work many times afterward. In the later flow of TV animation shifting to digital, I was taught various things at key points through part-time work, staying somewhat ahead of the curve.

Now, finally *Neighbourhood Story* work proper. This would become unexpectedly quite difficult.

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